

DR HARINDER K. BALI

At the Helm of India's Cardiac Revolution

India is facing a silent cardiac emergency. Heart disease remains the country's leading killer, and the age of those affected is dropping alarmingly fast. Young professionals collapsing at gyms and sudden cardiac arrests striking without warning have become unsettlingly common. This shift demands leaders who think ahead and act faster. One such leader is Dr Harinder K. Bali.

For more than four decades, he has stepped in precisely when survival seems unlikely, offering hope where others see an endpoint. A gold medallist from PGIMER, Chandigarh, Dr Bali went on to serve on its faculty, shaping a generation of future cardiologists. He pioneered primary angioplasty in northern India and made global headlines as the first to prove the value of stenting in Takayasu's Arteritis - published in world-leading journals including NEJM and JACC.

Yet behind the accolades stands a physician known for his humility and empathy, one who listens, who reassures, and who makes families feel cared for even in chaos. Colleagues call him the calmest mind in the room when every second counts.

Dr Bali's work with the National Interventional Council is driven by a clear goal: to ensure that expertise, advanced devices and evolving global techniques reach cardiologists across India.
He conducts training, guides young specialists and keeps a close eye on worldwide developments so that Indian patients are never left behind.

Today, he is at the forefront of some of the world's most advanced cardiac therapies. "We are making a lot of waves in the structural heart domain," he says, describing how elderly and high-risk patients who cannot undergo open-heart surgery can now be given a second chance at life through minimally invasive procedures like MitraClip.

He is equally passionate about saving patients who are extremely sick with those with multiple comorbidities, severe heart failure or advanced age. "In such patients, we use Impella, a miniature heart pump, which stabilizes the patient and safely completes the stenting," he explains.

India also has a large population with heavily calcified arteries, a unique challenge that requires expertise and advanced tools. To restore blood flow in these cases, Dr Bali deploys plaque-modifying techniques such as rotablation, orbital atherectomy, shockwave therapy and hybrid approaches like Rotatripsy. Combined with IVUS and OCT imaging before and after the procedure, this ensures precision, safety and long-term success.

He also points to the arrival of leadless pacemakers as a major leap forward. "It is a painless procedure. No pocket, no visible leads. Very minimal infection risk," he says, noting that the batteries can last up to 17 years.

Beyond the hospitals, Dr Bali remains deeply connected to society. An avid reader with a love for Urdu poetry and community work, he believes medicine must go beyond procedures. It must serve people. Through the HEART Foundation, he leads awareness drives, walkathons and vaccination support for the underprivileged. His family shares